

Two printers

Generally, black text printouts are taken in economy mode, while images are printed using the best quality mode. This requires you to change the printer options, to suit the print job at hand. Avoid this by installing another copy of the printer, but with a different name. Do this by going to **Control Panel > Printers**, and clicking Add New Printer. Now, use different default print settings for these two printers. You can choose either of them, to suit your printing needs.

Speed printing

Windows normally spools print jobs before sending them to the printer. Spooling involves writing the data to be printed, to a temporary file. This allows you to work while the printing in progress. However, this slows down the printing process. On most printers, you can turn off the spooler by going to **Start > Settings > Printers**. Right-click on the printer icon, select Properties, and then click Details. Click 'Spool Settings' at the bottom of the dialog box. Select the 'Print Directly to Printer' option. This will tie up your application until the printer has all the data, but your print job will be done faster. This option is handy if your print spooler crashes, and you need to print before you reboot your PC.

Print-related software

The standard print dialogue box doesn't provide all the

flexibility and customisation that you would like to have. There are various software that let you do them. One such software is FinePrint (www.fineprint.com). FinePrint is a Windows printer driver that provides you with advanced printing capabilities. It has some very useful features, such as the ability to add blank pages, and delete pages. The 'Ink Saver' provides options to convert coloured text to black, and to skip graphics. You can print multiple pages on a single sheet of paper, add watermarks, headers and footers, and you can even insert customised letterheads. It also allows you to design your printouts as an image, and also to retain the text format maintained in the Web page that you're printing from.

Another useful software is Directory Printer (www.galcott.com). With this, you can print the directory structure of your hard drive. It can print all the folder names and file names. It can also export the structure to a text file.

PaperlessPrinter (www.rarefind.com) allows you to convert printable documents to HTML, JPEG and BMP formats. You can use it to publish documents in HTML, JPEG or BMP, preserving their look and content—complete with fonts and graphics. You can distribute your HTML documents by e-mail, or store them on the Web, an intranet, a file system, or on a CD.

Stuck Print Jobs

Sometimes a print job gets stuck in the print queue. Viewing the queue shows that the job is being deleted, but it never is actually deleted, and other jobs don't move forward. To resolve this, you don't have to restart the print server, but only the print spooler. To do so, if you are using Windows 2000 or XP, open up the DOS prompt, and type in the command '**net stop spooler**'. Wait until the service stops, and then type in '**net start spooler**'. You can also do this by going to **Start > Settings > Control Panel > Administrative Tools > Services**, highlighting the Spooler service, right-clicking it and choosing Restart. Now you should be able to delete a stuck print job, if it is not deleted automatically.

Cleaning up old printer files

By default, any print jobs sent to a printer will be temporarily spooled to a folder on the hard drive. Usually, these files are deleted when the job has printed. Sometimes, these temporary files don't get deleted. If you're not expecting anything to be printed, you may safely delete any files in that folder. The default folder location is **%systemroot%\system32\spool\printers**, where **%systemroot%** is usually either 'C:\windows' or 'C:\winnt'.

If you want to change the location of this folder—because you want to free up space on your drive, or for

any other reason—go to **Start > Settings > Control Panel**, and click Printers. Now go to **File > Server Properties**. Under the Advanced tab, you'll see a field that says 'Spool Folder.' Here you can type in the new location path of the spool folder.

Printer pooling

If you are using Windows 2000 or XP, and using several identical printers, you can create a pool of the printers, that will enable Windows to balance the print jobs. To do this, connect all the printers to your



Create a pool if you have multiple, similar printers

machine on different ports. Install the drivers for one printer. Now go to **Start > Settings > Control Panel**, and double-click Printers. Right-click the printer name and click Properties. Under the Ports tab, tick 'Enable printer pooling.' Now tick all the ports to which your printers are connected. Click OK. Windows will automatically handle the allocation of print jobs across the printers.